HURRICANE HIMANTA

BEHIND THE BJP'S THIRD STRAIGHT VICTORY LIES CHIEF MINISTER HIMANTA BISWA SARMA'S WELFARE EXPANSION, CONSTITUENCY REDRAWING AND IDENTITY CONSOLIDATION, WHICH HAVE TILTED ASSAM'S POLITICS IN HIS FAVOUR

By Kaushik Deka



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On a humid afternoon in March, in Nalbari, Himanta Biswa Sarma stood atop an open jeep for 14 hours. Since 8.30 am, he had been waving at a sea of people lining the streets. Thousands jostled to touch him, kiss him, and hand him water bottles, home-cooked food, fruit, framed portraits, a shampoo bottle and a face wash. He drank from strangers' bottles, ate food handed up to him and ignored every protocol attached to a Z-Plus protectee.

Someone passed up a written application. He read it, photographed it on WhatsApp and sent instructions to the relevant officer, with barely a pause in his campaign demeanour. The road march ended at 10.30 pm. Ten hours later, it was to begin again.

On May 4, Assam returned its verdict. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) won 82 seats in the 126-member assembly, not only breaching the majority mark of 64, but also its best-ever performance. With its allies, the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) and the Bodoland People's Front, winning 10 seats each, the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) crossed the 100-seat mark. The Congress-led six-party Asom Sonmilito Morcha, with Gaurav Gogoi as its chief ministerial candidate, was reduced to 21 seats, with the Congress itself dropping 10—from 29 to 19.

For Sarma, winning was never enough; his vic-

